Fire on the Mountain: Character Quotations

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Fire on the Mountain: Key Character Quotations

In your exam, you will be asked to respond to questions on the themes and characters in Fire on the Mountain. Being able to support your ideas with relevant quotations from the novel, and to understand the context in which those quotations appear, will help you construct more developed and convincing responses.

If you can recall quotations linked to the novel's key themes, such as isolation, class, or patriarchy, you will find it easier to analyse how Desai presents characterisation and traces the development of figures such as Nanda Kaul, Raka, and Ila Das.

Here we will examine some important quotations from the following key characters:

- Nanda Kaul
- Raka
- Ila Das
- Ram Lal

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Quotations are not just for memorising, they are tools to help you prove your ideas in the exam. When revising Fire on the Mountain, focus on learning short, powerful quotations that link clearly to characters, themes, and key moments in the novel — this is why we include a "key word or phrase to memorise" for each longer quote below.

You should also think about what each quotation shows, not just what it says. A good key quote can reveal a character's motivation, a turning point in the plot, or Desai's message about loneliness or the class system in India. Using a few well-chosen quotations confidently is much more effective than trying to remember lots of long ones.

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

> **"Discharge me… I've discharged all my duties"** — Nanda, Part 1, Chapter 8

Key word or phrase to memorise: "Discharge me"	**What the quotation means**: Nanda feels she has finished her duties of caring for others.	**Theme**: Patriarchy/Trauma

• With Raka close to arriving, Nanda is suddenly reminded of how unhappy she was as a mother:
  ○ Nanda felt overwhelmed by the crowded, noisy household and lack of privacy, and disliked how little time she got to herself
• Nanda wants to be released from her duty, as she feels this is taking her freedom away from her once more
• By saying she has "discharged" all her duties, she is saying that she has done all this before:
  ○ She feels she has done her time, having been a mother and wife even when unhappy
• Nanda sees no prospect of joy in looking after Raka, just a burden		

> **"The care of others was a habit Nanda Kaul had mislaid. It had been a religious calling she had believed in till she found it fake"** — Narrator, Part 1, Chapter 9

Key word or phrase to memorise: "It had been a religious calling"	**What the quotation means**: Nanda used to care for people, but soon lost her love for it.	**Theme**: Trauma

• Once upon a time, Nanda had thought that caring for others was the most important thing, something she enjoyed and was passionate about, almost as if it were her calling
• Nowadays, Nanda is no longer someone who wants to care for others:
  ○ This may reflect disillusionment and long-term emotional exhaustion from her past life
  ○ She felt locked into her marriage and motherhood, with no escape
  ○ This has removed any joy or interest she had in the care of others
• This is a great indication of how her trauma has changed her:		

Help me understand

> **"Raka, you really *are* a great-grandchild of mine, aren't you?"** — Nanda, Part 2, Chapter 9

Key word or phrase to memorise: "A great-grandchild of mine"	**What the quotation means**: Nanda thinks she sees similarities between herself and Raka.	**Theme**: Solitude and loneliness

- Raka does not want to go to the club and socialise, and stands up for herself by saying that Nanda does not either:
  - Nanda briefly reads Raka's refusal as a sign of similarity, projecting her own self-image onto her
  - This is something Nanda thinks of herself, but it is wishful thinking
- Nanda tries to show little interest in Raka, but is consistently drawn in:
  - While Raka does not care, Nanda does and is not so naturally able to ignore people
- This is projection from Nanda, wishing she was like Raka

> **"It was all a lie, all. She had lied to Raka, lied about everything"** — Narrator, Part 3, Chapter 13

Key word or phrase to memorise: "It was all a lie"	**What the quotation means**: Nanda, in sudden grief, admits to herself that she has been lying about multiple aspects of her life and past.	**Theme**: Trauma

front she puts up to shield herself from pain

- With Ila's death confronting her, she breaks:
  - This is more than just admitting that she lied to Raka
  - Here she is admitting that she has lied to herself for a long time
  - Nanda has changed her personality and retreated into her shell so that she can block out her pain
- In the final moments of the book, she admits it to herself and to the reader, finally dispelling her fabrications:
  - Desai has been hinting at this throughout the narrative, and here it becomes clear

Raka

> **"The infant looked strangely aged, as if by worries and anxieties beyond its age, its little face black and wrinkled, its tear-drop eyes glistening with sadness"** — Narrator, Part 2, Chapter 7

Key word or phrase to memorise: "The infant looked strangely aged"	**What the quotation means**: Raka and Nanda are watching a mother **langur** and its baby.	**Theme**: Trauma

- Raka sees an infant **langur** with her mother, and the pair somewhat mirror Raka and Nanda watching them
- In this reading, the infant **langur** is symbolic of Raka:
  - Raka is a child who has been aged by the circumstances of her young life so far
  - The illnesses she has faced have left her looking thin and sickly
  - The abuse of her mother also has left her with mental scars of anxiety and trauma
- Both Raka and the **langur** are small figures tinged with sadness:
  - The tear-drop is literal for the **langur**
  - Raka is worn by sadness in her frailty and desire to be alone

> **"Somewhere behind them, behind it all, was her father, home from a party, stumbling and crashing through the curtains of night"** — Narrator, Part 2, Chapter 11

her father"	Raka has of her abusive father.	

- As Raka sees the drunken revellers at the club, she is reminded of her drunk father:
  - When he would stumble home drunk was when he was going to beat Raka's mother
- "Behind it all" is an interesting phrase here, as if her father's abuse of her mother is behind all her anxiety:
  - It has made her mother a shell of herself, and has left Raka fearful of drunken adults
  - Raka is clearly scared of adults out of control, knowing what they can do
- Raka might be free of this trauma in a different society, but the patriarchal systems of 20th-century India mean she has been trapped in a cycle of abuse:
  - Her grandmother pushes her mother back to her father over and over
  - As a professional man who is well respected in the community, his faults are looked past
  - There is a suggestion that Raka's mother needs to do better as a wife to be happy
  - Women and girls are valued less, so this trauma is seen as not important

> **"She was the only child Nanda Kaul had ever known who preferred to stand apart and go off and disappear to being loved, cared for and made the centre of attention"** — Narrator, Part 2, Chapter 14

Key word or phrase to memorise: "Preferred to stand apart and go off"	**What the quotation means**: Nanda has not known a child as independent as Raka.	**Theme**: Solitude and loneliness

- Nanda's confusion here is part of her seeing someone like Raka, who is comfortable alone, and noticing the difference in how she feels when by herself:
  - Nanda has been lying to herself about her own happiness
  - Raka exposes this, because Nanda sees how comfortable she is and realises she is not as content
- It can also be questioned whether this is true:
  - Nanda found her own children too much to bear, and she may have felt that they were all attention-seeking
  - Equally, Nanda barely remembers the difference between her children and grandchildren, and cannot be trusted to recall correctly

> **"She could not bear to be confined to the old lady's fantasy world when the reality outside appealed so strongly"** — Narrator, Part 2, Chapter 20

Key word or phrase to memorise: "Confined to the old lady's fantasy world"	**What the quotation means**: Raka is not interested in Nanda and wants to be left to explore.	**Theme**: Solitude and loneliness

• It is possible that Raka is seeing through Nanda's lies:
  ○ She may believe it a "fantasy world" because she believes Nanda's self-confidence and happiness being alone to be false
• Another possibility is that she does not care about Nanda's memories:
  ○ To her, they are a tale of the past, and an example of Nanda living in her fantasy of those days, rather than the present day
• Raka is interested in the world around her, and wants to go off alone:
  ○ Raka has rarely been interested in Nanda as a person
  ○ She does not want to be here with her in Kasauli
  ○ She also does not want to be stuck in conversation
• This shows the difference between the pair:
  ○ Nanda cares about what Raka thinks and what she does
  ○ Raka has little interest in Nanda because she appears far more comfortable alone outdoors than in social settings		

Ila Das

> **"How lovely the house looks, Nanda. *Dear* Carignano. Now if you were to see *my* castle…"** — Ila Das, Part 3, Chapter 3

Key word or phrase to memorise: "*Dear* Carignano"	**What the quotation means**: Ila has great respect for a beautiful house that once housed British dignitaries.	**Theme**: Class system
• To Ila Das, who grew up with wealth and status, a big and important house would be a sign of achievement • Ila would also recognise the significance of Carignano:		

the British, a system she existed in comfortably for much of her life
    - She was raised to respect status and wealth
- This may also reflect Ila's shame about her current situation:
    - With wealth and status important in her upbringing, living in poverty is likely something she is ashamed of
    - She mockingly mentions her "castle" to deflect from her shame

> **"Thinking of Nanda Kaul, how beautiful she still was, how gracefully she poured the tea, how sympathetically she listened"** — Narrator, Part 3, Chapter 11

Key word or phrase to memorise: "How sympathetically she listened"	**What the quotation means**: Ila sees the best in Nanda, even when Nanda's emotional distance seems to be clear.	**Theme**: Trauma

- For Ila, thinking the best of others and assuming kindness helps to protect her from her pain:
    - She thinks the best of Nanda because that is best for her
    - If she sees Nanda is being kind, then someone is showing her care and respect, which she rarely gets
    - Ila has been regularly mocked all her life, but needs to deflect it
- This is also a sign of her naivety:
    - Her comfortable upbringing has left her without a sense of the real world
    - Nanda offers her no support and was reluctant to hear a word she said, but Ila would never consider this to be true

Ram Lal

> **"When the Angrez Sahibs and Memsahibs had dances"** — Ram Lal, Part 2, Chapter 10

"Sahibs and Memsahibs"	put on by the upper-classes — the men (sahibs) and women (memsahibs).	

- Ram Lal is still a servant, even after the British have left, and is still using the language of their rule:
  - By using these terms, he is showing himself as being beneath the status of these people
- This is a reminder that the **British Raj** being over does not mean its impact is gone:
  - Many of its power structures remain, and people raised in these times are going to continue on similarly
  - This is especially true of those who benefit from it, and the upper-class are likely to let these structures remain in place as it benefits them
  - The novel suggests colonial language and hierarchy persist; their decline seems to be very gradual

Sources

Desai, A. (1999) *Fire on the Mountain* (Vintage)

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